China’s economic growth has gone hand in hand with greater Chinese assertiveness, as can be seen in the pursuit of its territorial interests in recent years. China has begun to challenge the United States as the exclusive security provider in East Asia. Indeed, through its growing anti-access/area-denial capacity, China has thrown a gauntlet to the United States. Even in the new dimensions of warfare, especially space and cyberspace, China’s prowess is growing formidably.[39]

Bordering 14 countries and with economic and territorial stakes in the maritime space around itself in the East China and South China Seas, China has strong imperatives for a large increase in its military investments. Continuing mayhem in the Middle East and the troubling impact it might have on Central Asia, as well as Afghanistan’s slow unravelling and its immediate negative impact on China’s close ally, Pakistan, and future adverse effect on Xinjiang all are of concern to China, as is the continuing tension in North Asia, the standoff between the United States and Russia over Ukraine, and the US pivot to Asia. Furthermore, China has recently abandoned Deng Xiaoping’s dictum “keep a low profile and bide your time,”[40] and Beijing has expanded and redefined its “core interests.”[41] All these developments have together led China to buttress its military power.

China’s increased military investments have evoked “adversarial reactions” in its neighbourhood.[42] States are taking countervailing measures to augment their security, several by leaning on other great powers to help them with money and material or by forging closer ties with them as insurance against China.[43] China’s robust pursuit of its interests has accomplished the unimaginable: a growing rapprochement between Japan and South Korea[44] and between Vietnam and the United States.[45] South Korea, stung by China’s inability to effectively address the security threat it faces from DPRK, is ready to deploy the THAAD